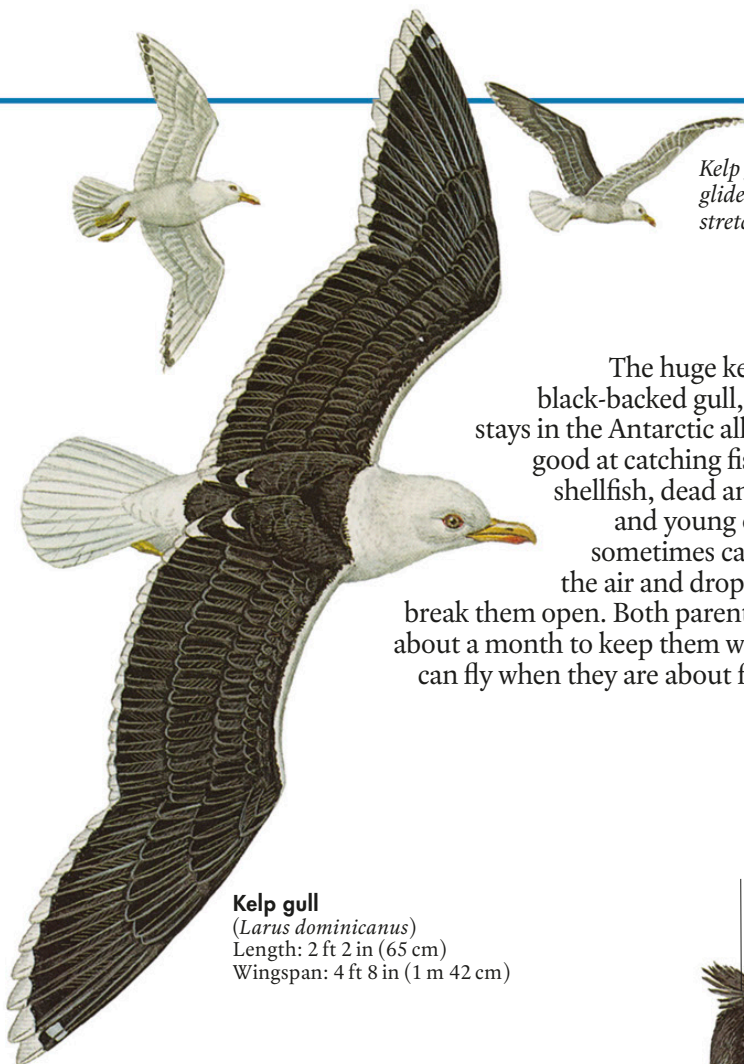


Antarctica



ANTARCTICA IS THE coldest and windiest place on Earth. Unlike the Arctic, which is an ocean surrounded by land, Antarctica is a huge area of land surrounded by ocean. Most of the land is covered by ice. Little rain or snow falls, so there is hardly any fresh water for birds to drink.

All birds in Antarctica are coastal. Seabirds have denser feathers than most land birds to keep them warm, and are better at flying in stormy weather. In summer, some of the ice around the coasts melts and millions of seabirds such as albatrosses, petrels, penguins, and shearwaters come ashore to lay eggs and raise their young. The Antarctic summer lasts for only about four months when it is light most of the time. During the winter, most of the birds leave Antarctica and roam widely over the southern oceans in search of food.



Kelp gulls fly slowly and often glide with their long wings stretched out.

Kelp gull

The huge kelp gull, or southern black-backed gull, is the only gull that stays in the Antarctic all year. Kelp gulls are good at catching fish, but they also eat shellfish, dead animals, and the eggs and young of other birds. They sometimes carry shellfish up into the air and drop them onto rocks to break them open. Both parents sit on the eggs for about a month to keep them warm, and the chicks can fly when they are about five to six weeks old.

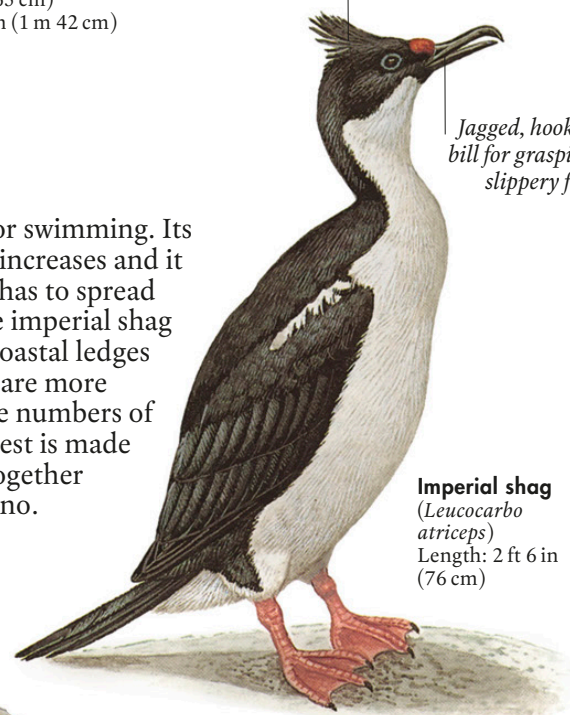
Kelp gull
(*Larus dominicanus*)
Length: 2 ft 2 in (65 cm)
Wingspan: 4 ft 8 in (1 m 42 cm)

Birds grow wispy crests in the breeding season.

Jagged, hooked bill for grasping slippery fish

Imperial shag

The imperial shag has webbed feet for swimming. Its feathers soak up water, so its weight increases and it can sink and dive more easily. But it has to spread out its wings to dry after a swim. The imperial shag nests in huge colonies on sheltered coastal ledges or among rocks. The helpless young are more likely to survive where there are large numbers of adults to drive away attackers. The nest is made of a pile of seaweed, which is stuck together with the birds' droppings, called guano.

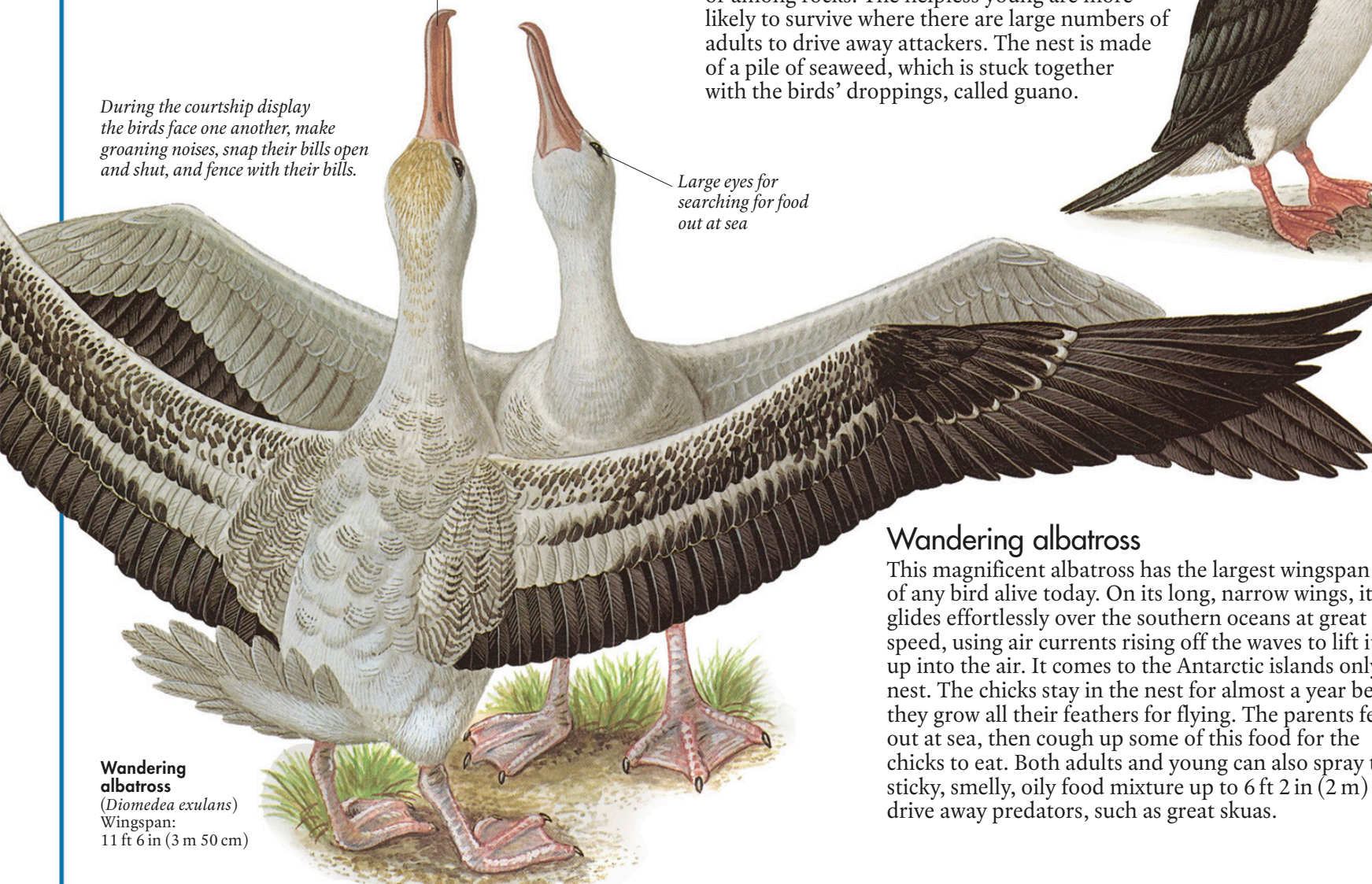


Imperial shag
(*Leucocarbo atriceps*)
Length: 2 ft 6 in (76 cm)

Huge, hooked bill for gobbling up fish or squid

During the courtship display the birds face one another, make groaning noises, snap their bills open and shut, and fence with their bills.

Large eyes for searching for food out at sea



Wandering albatross
(*Diomedea exulans*)
Wingspan:
11 ft 6 in (3 m 50 cm)

Wandering albatross

This magnificent albatross has the largest wingspan of any bird alive today. On its long, narrow wings, it glides effortlessly over the southern oceans at great speed, using air currents rising off the waves to lift it up into the air. It comes to the Antarctic islands only to nest. The chicks stay in the nest for almost a year before they grow all their feathers for flying. The parents feed out at sea, then cough up some of this food for the chicks to eat. Both adults and young can also spray this sticky, smelly, oily food mixture up to 6 ft 2 in (2 m) to drive away predators, such as great skuas.